

# Mesopotamian Civilization

A Detailed Overview

# Introduction

- Mesopotamian Civilization emerged between the Tigris and Euphrates Rivers in present-day Iraq, Syria, and Iran. It was one of the earliest civilizations, influencing law, governance, and technology.

# Major Civilizations of Mesopotamia

- - Sumerians (3100 – 2000 BCE): First cities and writing system
- - Akkadians (2334 – 2154 BCE): First empire under Sargon
- - Babylonians (1894 – 539 BCE): Hammurabi's Code, Babylon
- - Assyrians (1365 – 609 BCE): Military expansion, Nineveh
- - Chaldeans (626 – 539 BCE): Nebuchadnezzar II, Hanging Gardens

# Urbanization and Cities

- - Major cities: Ur, Uruk, Babylon, Nineveh
- - City-states with independent rulers
- - Ziggurats: Temples for religious and political purposes

# Social Structure

- 1. Kings and Nobles – Rulers, claimed divine authority
- 2. Priests – Controlled temples, had political influence
- 3. Merchants and Artisans – Engaged in trade and craftwork
- 4. Farmers and Laborers – Majority of the population
- 5. Slaves – Prisoners of war or debt slaves

# Economy and Trade

- - Agriculture: Wheat, barley, dates, flax
- - Domesticated animals: Sheep, cattle, goats
- - Trade with Indus Valley, Egypt, and Anatolia
- - Standardized weights and measures for commerce

# Religion and Beliefs

- - Polytheistic: Worshiped gods like Anu, Enlil, Ishtar, and Marduk
- - Ziggurats served as religious centers
- - Priests played a key role in governance
- - Belief in the afterlife, though viewed as dark and dreary

# Writing and Education

- - Developed cuneiform script on clay tablets
- - Used for record-keeping, laws, and literature
- - The Epic of Gilgamesh: One of the oldest literary works



# Law and Governance

- - Hammurabi's Code: First written legal system
- - Laws covered trade, property, marriage, and crime
- - Centralized rule in Babylon, military expansion

# Science and Technology

- - Invented the wheel, plow, and sailboat
- - Developed advanced irrigation for agriculture
- - Mathematics: Base-60 system (influenced timekeeping)
- - Astronomy: Created lunar calendars

# Famous Rulers

- - Sargon of Akkad: Founded first empire
- - Hammurabi: Introduced legal code
- - Ashurbanipal: Built Library of Nineveh
- - Nebuchadnezzar II: Constructed Hanging Gardens

# Decline of Mesopotamian Civilization

- - Warfare among city-states weakened them
- - Invasions by Persians, Greeks, and others
- - Environmental changes affected agriculture
- - 539 BCE: Persian King Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon

# Legacy of Mesopotamian Civilization

- - First writing system (Cuneiform) influenced later scripts
- - Legal codes inspired future law systems
- - Contributions in mathematics and astronomy
- - Urban planning and irrigation techniques influenced later civilizations

# Conclusion

- Mesopotamian Civilization shaped human history through innovations in governance, law, writing, and urban planning. Its achievements continue to influence modern society.